Debates in the Philosophy of AI

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User prompt: Using web search, identify ten currently active debates in the philosophy of artificial intelligence. For each, give: (a) the open question in one sentence; (b) the two or three main rival positions; (c) three anchor papers from 2023 or later, with full citations and links; (d) why the debate is still unsettled. Prefer debates where positions are still forming over debates with a large settled literature. Do not propose a thesis of your own.

Response: Here are ten currently active, unsettled debates in the philosophy of artificial intelligence, focusing on emerging questions driven by recent advances in large language models (LLMs) and generative systems.

1. Phenomenal Consciousness in LLMs

(a) Open question: Could current or near-future large language models possess phenomenal consciousness (subjective experience)? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Computational Functionalism:** Consciousness arises from specific functional organizations; if an AI replicates the right computational structures (e.g., global workspace, recurrent processing), it can be conscious.
- **Biological Chauvinism:** Consciousness is strictly tied to the biological wetware and physical properties of carbon-based brains, making silicon-based sentience impossible.
- **Illusionism/Agnosticism:** The "hard problem" makes empirical verification of AI consciousness impossible, or the concept of phenomenal consciousness itself is a human illusion misapplied to machines. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Chalmers, 2023)
- (Butlin et al., 2023)
- (Karimi, n.d.) **(d) Why unsettled:** There is no universally accepted scientific or neurobiological theory of human consciousness, making it impossible to establish definitive, universally agreed-upon empirical markers for artificial sentience.

2. Epistemology of AI Outputs: Truth, Lies, and Bullshit

(a) Open question: Do large language models engage in asserting truth, lying, or generating epistemic "bullshit" when they produce falsehoods? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Soft Bullshitting:** LLMs do not lie because they lack beliefs or intentions to deceive; instead, they are "bullshit machines" structurally indifferent to the truth of their outputs.
- **Fictionalism/Simulation:** LLMs do not make epistemic assertions at all; they are simulators playing conversational games or generating interactive fiction based on probability.
- **Emergent Knowledge Tracking:** Through sheer scale, models encode genuine world models and can be said to possess a form of distributed knowledge, making their errors akin to cognitive hallucinations. **(c) Anchor papers:**

- (Gorrieri, 2024)
- (Mugleston et al., 2025)
- Hicks, M. T., Humphries, J., & Slater, J. (2024). "ChatGPT is bullshit." *Ethics and Information Technology*. Link **(d) Why unsettled:** Determining whether an entity can "lie" or "bullshit" hinges on unresolved debates in the philosophy of mind regarding whether intention, belief, and care for the truth can be functionally ascribed to a system without a stable, internal subjective worldview.

3. The Moral Status and Patiency of AI Systems

(a) Open question: Should AI systems that exhibit behaviors associated with sentience or reasoning be granted moral status and rights? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Precautionary Status:** Given our uncertainty about machine consciousness, we should grant moral patiency defensively to avoid the risk of inflicting massive, unrecognized suffering.
- **Strict Denial (Instrumentalism):** AI systems are purely artifacts and tools; granting them moral status is a category error that dangerously dilutes human rights.
- **Relational/Social Status:** Moral status does not depend on an AI's hidden internal properties (which we cannot verify) but on its social role and how it is integrated into human relational networks. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Navon, n.d.)
- (Schwitzgebel, 2023)
- Edmonds, D. (2024). *AI Morality*. Oxford University Press. Link **(d) Why unsettled:** The debate sits at the intersection of unresolved metaphysics (what makes something a moral patient) and urgent policy (how to regulate human-AI interaction), complicated by AI's ability to perfectly mimic emotional vulnerability.

4. Machine Agency and Autonomy

(a) Open question: Can language models integrated into agentic loops (with memory and tool-use) be considered genuine autonomous agents? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Genuine Goal-Directed Agency:** When given continuous feedback loops and environmental interaction, models cross the threshold into genuine, belief-desire-driven agency.
- **Derived/Simulated Agency:** AI systems only simulate agency; their goals are entirely derived from human prompts and training distributions, lacking true autonomy.
- **Embodied/Enactive Agency:** True agency requires self-constitution, spatio-temporal continuity, and biological survival imperatives, which disembodied software fundamentally lacks. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Butlin, 2024)
- Barandiaran, X. E. et al. (2026). "Transforming Agency. On the mode of existence of Large Language Models." Link

- Opara, C. (2024). "The creative agency of large language models: a philosophical inquiry." Link **(d) Why unsettled:** Historical definitions of "agency" were developed exclusively for biological organisms. Philosophers are currently struggling to agree on whether these concepts can be functionally abstracted to pure software.

5. Mechanistic Interpretability and Epistemic Opacity

(a) Open question: Can mechanistic interpretability resolve the "black box" problem of deep neural networks to provide genuine scientific understanding? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Explanatory Reductionism:** Neural networks can eventually be fully decomposed into human-interpretable circuits, features, and causal mechanisms.
- **Fundamental Epistemic Opacity:** High-dimensional representations (characterized by polysemanticity and superposition) are fundamentally alien and cannot be reduced to human-understandable concepts without losing accuracy.
- **Explanatory Pluralism:** We cannot rely on strict bottom-up mechanistic reduction; understanding AI requires integrating multiple, distinct levels of abstraction simultaneously. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Williams, n.d.)
- Sharkey, L. et al. (2025). "Mechanistic Interpretability Needs Philosophy." (Discussed via Williams, n.d.)
- Kästner, L., & Crook, A. (2024). "Mechanistic interpretability..." (Discussed via Williams, n.d.) **(d) Why unsettled:** The mathematical realities of neural networks challenge traditional philosophical accounts of how parts relate to wholes, forcing a re-evaluation of what constitutes a "scientific explanation."

6. Normative Foundations of AI Alignment

(a) Open question: Which human values should AI systems be aligned with, and what normative framework justifies that choice? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Preference Utilitarianism (Preference Matching):** AI should maximize the satisfaction of the aggregate preferences of its human users.
- **Deontological/Fiduciary Alignment:** AI should be bound by strict rules, fundamental rights, and fiduciary duties of loyalty to users, regardless of aggregate utility.
- **Polycentric/Democratic Alignment:** Alignment is inherently political; values cannot be pre-programmed mathematically but must be continuously negotiated through diverse, democratic institutional oversight. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Zhi-Xuan, n.d.)
- (Lange, n.d.)
- (Kolt, n.d.) **(d) Why unsettled:** "Alignment" is not purely a technical computer science problem; it inherits the entirety of human moral disagreement. Solving it requires resolving

foundational debates in political philosophy regarding how societies should govern competing values.

7. Artificial Creativity and Authorship

(a) Open question: Can generative AI systems be considered genuine creators, or are they merely synthesizing human pastiche? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Genuine Computational Creativity:** Generative models meet the criteria for creativity by producing artifacts that are novel, valuable, and surprising.
- **Derivative Combinatorics:** AI models lack the intentionality, experiential grounding, and vulnerability required for authentic creativity; they are merely high-dimensional statistical collages.
- **Synergistic Co-Creation:** Creativity should no longer be viewed as an individualistic human trait, but as a hybrid system where collective human knowledge (the training data) interfaces with algorithmic tools. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Desdevises, n.d.)
- Sanz, M. (2025). "Generative AI, Collective Knowledge, and the Path Towards Human Synergy." Link
- Camarda, A. et al. (2024). (Referenced in Desdevises regarding cognitive fixation). **(d) Why unsettled:** The debate blurs cognitive science (the mechanics of divergent thinking) with aesthetics and copyright law (the social definition of artistic intent and ownership).

8. Existential Risk (X-Risk) Epistemology

(a) Open question: Are arguments predicting near-term existential catastrophe from artificial superintelligence epistemically warranted? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Catastrophic Default (Orthogonality Thesis):** Superintelligence is likely to have goals orthogonal to human survival, and instrumental convergence makes catastrophic risk a highly probable default without perfect alignment.
- **Moral Math Skepticism:** X-Risk calculations rely on flawed "moral mathematics," unjustified assumptions about population dynamics, and poorly grounded decision theories.
- **Ideological Distraction:** Focusing on speculative future extinction events is a secular eschatology that distracts from urgent, near-term algorithmic harms (bias, labor displacement, and power centralization). **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Thorstad, n.d.)
- Thorstad, D. (2024). "Mistakes in the Moral Mathematics of Existential Risk." Link
- Sheposh, R. (2023). "Existential risk from artificial general intelligence." Link **(d) Why unsettled:** It relies on deep uncertainties regarding future technological capabilities, unprovable priors about how superintelligence might behave, and competing philosophical models for discounting future time horizons.

9. Social Robots, Deception, and Artificial Intimacy

(a) Open question: Is it ethically permissible to design social robots or companion AIs that simulate human emotions, thereby deceiving their users? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Harmful Deception:** Simulated affection degrades human dignity, exploits vulnerable populations (e.g., the elderly), and damages the fabric of authentic social relationships.
- **Pragmatic Care (Utilitarianism):** If artificial intimacy successfully mitigates loneliness and provides psychological comfort, the utility outweighs the abstract harm of deception.
- **Playful Fictionalism:** Users are not genuinely deceived; they engage in a willing suspension of disbelief, treating the AI as an interactive fiction rather than a real person. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- Sebastiani, F. et al. (2024). "Human-robot dynamics: a psychological insight into the ethics of deception." Link
- Sparrow, R. & Sparrow, L. (critiqued in current literature, e.g., "Self-Deception in Human–AI Emotional Relations", 2024). Link
- (Schwitzgebel, 2023) **(d) Why unsettled:** It pitches utilitarian psychological benefits (loneliness mitigation) directly against deontological commitments to truth, authenticity, and human dignity.

10. Semantic Competence and Grounding in LLMs

(a) Open question: Do large language models possess genuine semantic understanding of the words they produce, or are they purely syntactic pattern matchers? **(b) Rival positions:**

- **Eliminativism (Stochastic Parrots):** LLMs lack grounding in the physical world; they only manipulate ungrounded syntax and therefore cannot understand meaning (an updated Chinese Room argument).
- **Relational Semantics (Structuralism):** Meaning is defined by use and context; LLMs possess deep structural understanding of concepts through high-dimensional relationships, bypassing the need for physical embodiment.
- **Hybrid Grounding:** While pure text LLMs lack grounding, multimodal models integrated with vision, robotics, or tool use achieve genuine referential grounding. **(c) Anchor papers:**
- (Mugleston et al., 2025)
- "On Large Language Models and Understanding." (2023). Link
- (Biosca Pérez, n.d.) [Addresses ethical boundaries tied to cognitive interpretation]. **(d) Why unsettled:** The debate forces philosophers to precisely define what constitutes "meaning." It tests whether referential grounding (pointing to real objects) is strictly necessary for comprehension, or if conceptual role semantics (how words relate to other words) is sufficient.

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